Goa has long been fabled as the land of sun and sea, the proverbial melting pot marked by an intermingling of cultures. What many do not know is that the beginnings of Goa, locally termed as Goemkarponn, is deeply rooted in divinity. According to mythology, Parashuram, the warrior-sage and the sixth avatar of Lord Vishnu, created the Sahyadri range by throwing his divine axe (*parashu*) to reclaim land from the sea. This act of the sage created the entire western coast, known as the Konkan belt, with Goa (Gomantak) being a significant part of it.

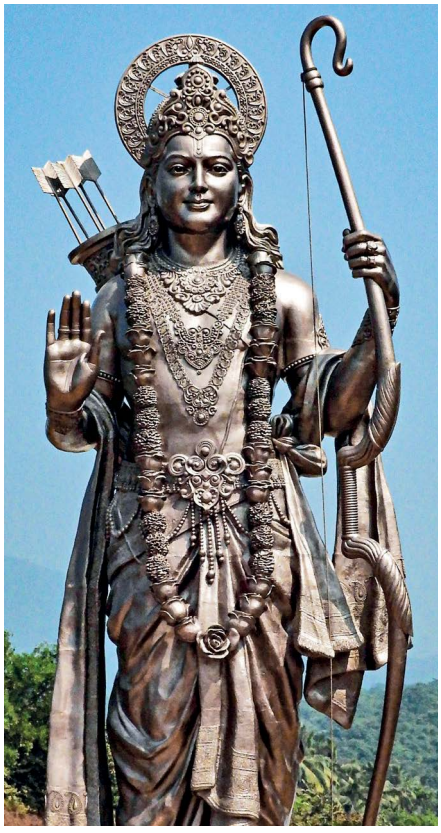
Thus, legend has it that Goa is Parashuram Bhoomi, a sacred land created by a divine figure. To sanctify the land, Parashuram apparently invited a few Brahmin families to settle there, initiating religious practices and temple traditions that continue to this day.

The country's smallest state has hundreds of temples in the various traditions of Hinduism. The Goa tourism department has of late started an 'Ekadasha Teertha', or 'Eleven Places of Transformation', a spiritual pilgrimage circuit featuring 11 significant temples that reflect the state's rich spiritual heritage. The initiative aims to promote spiritual and regenerative tourism by offering tourists a deeper connection to the local culture, history and spiritual traditions. Here are the five most prominent temples in Goa.

MUST-SEE

77 FT STATUE OF LORD RAM IN SOUTH GOA

Head to South Goa to see the 77-foot bronze statue of Lord Ram at the Shree Samsthan Gokarn Partagali Jeevottam Math in Partagali. The statue was installed to mark the 550th year celebration of the Math of the Gaud Saraswat Brahmins



PTI



Shanta Durga Temple, Ponda

Originally based in Keloshi, the Shri Shantadurga Mandir moved to its present location in Kavlem in the 18th century much after the Portuguese destroyed the original temple in 1566. Dedicated to goddess Durga, the temple also has Lord Shiva and Lord Vishnu as part of the reigning deities. According to legend, Durga acted as a peacekeeper between Shiva and Vishnu during their quarrel. The temple, also known as the Shree Shantadurga